MAKE IT DO · FREE SHEET

What things cost the year you were born

1940

IN 1940	THE RECORD	TODAY	IN OUR HOUSE
A pound of white bread per pound	8¢	**$1.87** per pound	
A dozen eggs per dozen	33¢	**$4.25** per dozen	
Half a gallon of milk delivered to the door	26¢	**$2.03** half a gallon, at the store	
A pound of butter per pound	36¢	**$4.76** per pound	
A pound of round steak per pound	36¢	**$8.86** per pound	
A pound of bacon per pound	27¢	**$7.02** per pound	
A pound of coffee per pound	21¢	**$8.18** per pound	
Five pounds of sugar 5-pound bag	26¢	**$5.12** 5 pounds	
Ten pounds of potatoes 10-pound bag	24¢	**$9.63** 10 pounds	
A stamp for a letter first-class, first ounce	3¢	**82¢** Forever stamp	
A month's rent median gross rent (census year)	$27.00	—	
An hour's pay at the federal minimum	30¢	**$7.25**	

IN 1940	THE RECORD	TODAY	IN OUR HOUSE
from Oct. 24, 1939		federal minimum since 2009	

THE NAMES IN THE HOSPITAL NURSERY, 1940

Girls: Mary, Barbara, Patricia, Judith, Betty. **Boys:** James, Robert, John, William, Richard.

One dollar in 1940 buys about what **$23.00** buys today (consumer price index, 2025 average). The last column is yours: write in what it cost in your house.

Where every number comes from. U.S. Bureau of the Census, Historical Statistics of the United States, Colonial Times to 1970, Part 1, p. 213, series E 188, 189, 192, 193, 194, 195, 197, 200, 202 (retail food prices, BLS); United States Postal Service, Historian, "Rates for Domestic Letters Since 1863" (September 2021), Table "Postage in Cents, per Ounce" (effective dates), p. 1 (single-page PDF); U.S. Census Bureau, Historical Census of Housing Tables: Gross Rents, "Median Gross Rents: Unadjusted", United States row, column 1940; U.S. Department of Labor, Wage and Hour Division, History of Federal Minimum Wage Rates Under the Fair Labor Standards Act, 1938-2009 (1938 Act column). Today: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics average prices, 2025 average; USPS 2026.

From the Make It Do film
Everyday Life in 1950s America,
in Real Color Film